

attractive, making things a bit easier to use". Some of today's product designers do indeed end up making designs that are only fit to be found in exhibitions and art galleries.

Product design could also be more about what Rodger Martin, a business school professor at the University of Toronto suggests – "integrative thinking". That's the ability to utilise opposing ideas and opposing constraints to create world-changing innovations. The stress is on world-changing, while the opposing ideas and constraints here are conditions that every product inherently should fulfil – desirability, technical feasibility and economic viability.

Paul Sandip's designs have garnered him substantial recognition abroad. He is a great exponent of contextual innovation and went on to explain what it means. "Emerging markets need new products and fresh designs that have not been force-fitted to the new environment. While designing for a new market segment, an in-depth study of its culture, lifestyle, and preferences becomes vital to be able to effectively determine the type of products, services, messages, or strategies that will fulfil the needs best. Contextual innovation is a consumer insight-driven design process that puts users at the very front of product development, creating an entirely new kind of usability-driven product platform," he said. He believes in redefining the mundane and ubiquitous to create something that is completely new. "When we re-define, as the word itself suggests, we work on the soul of the product, we question its very existence. Thus, giving the product a new mind and a fresh body," he adds.

A report by Boston University on product design and product personality says, "Design is not just a cultural phenomenon; it is also a key strategic variable that can assist companies in securing or defending a marketplace

advantage." Yet, design is now very much as part of pop culture with even a full featured reality show on BBC called Design For Life. The show is hosted by the famous recusant French designer Philippe Starck who is in search of the next rising star of product design from amongst 12 rather nice-to-look-at student finalists.

Eskild Hansen, the Head of the European Design Center at Cisco had a slightly different view of design and one that the new breed of goatee-sporting-designer-glares-toting bohemian designers of today will not like. He says "Design is an integrated and strategic part of building big businesses. Integrated means if you have a strategy in a business group it's important for designers to support that strategy. The design should be integrated into different business groups like technology, engineering, the market, customers and finally design. If all these are aligned towards the same thing you get good design."

Incidentally, design is theoretically defined as "the idea generation, concept development, testing and manufacturing or implementation of a physical object or service." and that "Product Designers conceptualise and evaluate ideas, making them tangible through products in a more systematic approach." Hence, there are certain elements of design remain constant irrespective of the school of thought from which product design is looked at.

Elements of design: Why do certain products look good and function well while some don't? **Aesthetics**

In product design, this branch of study relates to our sensory responses to an object. If an object is aesthetically appealing, it is pleasurable to look at, to touch and feel. Sandip says "Looking good is subjective. However there are

certain ways to achieve universally appealing aesthetics." According to him, the first principle is – Body attracts. A well resolved form factor always helps.

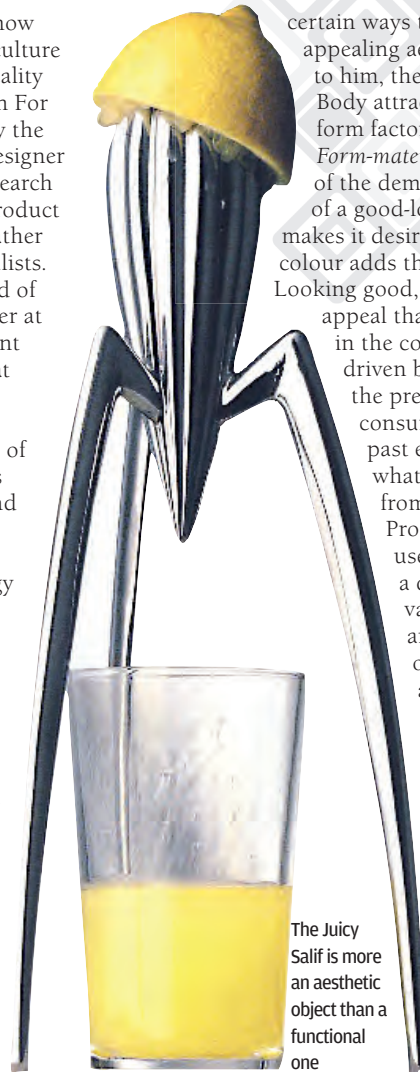
Form-material relation is one of the demanding parameters of a good-looking product. It makes it desirable. And finally, colour adds the oomph factor! Looking good, or more so the appeal that a product induces in the consumer is mainly driven by understanding the preferences of the consumer based on their past experiences, and what would they desire from the product. Products that a person uses are in one way a depiction of one's values, personality and the image that one wishes to portray as an individual, and hence the consumer should be able to relate to the product with the attributes that depict the same values, personality and image. When products look good to consumers, they meet these attributes, and when they don't, they are never

noticed after the first few months of release.

Aesthetics are therefore determined a great deal by emotion too. Take the case of a seemingly simple and ordinary object like a orange juicer that was designed Philippe Starck. The orange squeezer came to be known as the Juicy Salif and went on to become a cult product. These pieces became coveted objects and in turn all the more desirable. Hence, novelty, fashion, symbology also form a part of aesthetics.

Ergonomics and Interface design

Ergonomics has a lot to do with the human interface that machines have to be built with. As a science, it tries to improve human interactions with products, equipment, environments and systems. It takes into account human biology, stress analysis and material engineering to make products that can be more easily used and will cause less stress to the human body.



The Juicy Salif is more an aesthetic object than a functional one



The crew of the reality TV show – Design for life